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Software Evaluation
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Digital technology such as personal computers, Pocket PCs, iPods, and cell phones is becoming part of people's everyday lives and will become indispensable. The use of personal digital technology has permeated the lives of people all over the world. Cell phones are a good example of a personal digital device and are soon to become a unique identifier for a person. Many companies in Silicon Valley are already developing applications that treat cell phones as credit cards (e.g., www.obopay.com).

Another good example is the new Windows Vista and the 2007 Microsoft Office system. Are people ready for another Windows upgrade, or are they just seemingly trying to keep current with the latest technology? Perhaps a question to ask is whether the current Windows operating system is doing what it is supposed to do. Unless you are an advanced user and need additional graphics (or UI) capabilities, you may not need to upgrade. For most typical home users and occasional Internet surfers, it is not wise to upgrade, as they may also need to upgrade their computer system and require more memory.

One thing to know is that personal digital technology is controlled by operating systems and software applications. In many cases, software applications are way behind the development of digital technology. In development, digital hardware (or device) is always several generations ahead of the operating software. Unless there is a software application that can take advantage of Windows Vista, there is no point in upgrading. In other words, if a user upgrades their Windows, they are not taking advantage of Windows Vista and its new capabilities.

As educators, we face software choices. Some software is excellent, and some is absolutely terrible. I think that we should be prepared to systematically examine computer software before we use it. Some of the issues that we need to address are: 1) how you evaluate software, 2) what categories you should use to determine the effectiveness of the package, and 3) what other considerations you should make. Many educators are just users, not experts in the field; therefore, they may need to seek advice from a domain-knowledge expert or a college technology specialist.

A. Which do you have the most prior experience with?

Visualization tools: Windows XP and Microsoft Office 2005 System, Linux, JDeveloper, Microsoft .NET Development Studio.

B. Which do you feel is the most relevant to your current work situation?

Visualization Tools and cognitive systems: JDeveloper and Microsoft .NET Development Studio (IDE), and Microsoft Office System. I'm using JDeveloper and IDE to model classes and implement software solutions. I am also using Microsoft Excel and Access to design a database and to build an entity-relationship diagram.

C. Which would you have liked to have had available to you when you were a younger student (K-12 through college)?

There were not many graphical applications during my time in grades K-12. I am a visual learner; therefore, I prefer a graphical learning tool. As the old saying goes, a picture is worth a thousand words.